

There is no denying that last-minute pull-outs of several top-ranked boxers for the year-ending event left a depleted field, paving the way for easier draws and the participation of second-choice boxers from abroad.

With pugilists giving their best at the World Championships in Liverpool in September, it was not easy to push themselves again in November.

"Many boxers pulled out as it was difficult to attain one's peak within a short period of time. Some of them who came here witnessed a dip in their performance because of this," said a coach working at the national camp. According to Indian men's head coach Dharmendra Yadav, as the International Boxing Association (IBA) hosted another event offering big prize money around the same time, it lured top boxers from some countries that were affiliated to both old and new international federations, IBA and World Boxing (WB), respectively.

The field was further diminished, especially in the women's section. The maximum number of boxers competing in a women's weight was five, while the minimum was three, in 75kg and 80kg, where one boxer each, including Pooja Rani in 80kg, directly reached the final.

In the men's section, the maximum and minimum numbers of participants were eight and five, respectively.

The home advantage, including a familiar environment and the support of local spectators, also proved crucial for the Indians.

Taking nothing away from the Indian boxers' performance, a discernible section of the boxing fraternity present at the venue thought that dodgy judging favoured the home pugilists in some close bouts.

Nevertheless, the Indian contingent noted several encouraging moments.

The return of three promising women boxers, including Paris Olympian Preeti Pawar (54kg), 2022 World Championships bronze medallist and Asian champion



Parveen Hooda (60kg), and former World youth champion Arundhati Choudhary (70kg), was significant ahead of important events in the next few years.

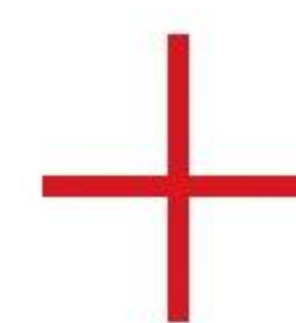
Preeti, who overcame her battle with Hepatitis-A before the Paris Olympics, made a commendable comeback as she toppled two accomplished rivals, Olympic medallist and triple World champion Hsiao Wen Huang of Chinese Taipei and two-time World Championships medallist Sirine Charaabi of Italy, to take gold.

Parveen, who struggled after being suspended for a whereabouts failure that resulted in the forfeiture

**Strong will:** World champion Jaismine Lamboria's (in blue) grit was on full display at the World Boxing Cup Finals as the southpaw clinched the 57kg title despite battling a left shoulder injury.

SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

of an Olympics berth, also went past two formidable opponents, World Championships silver medallist Aneta Rygielska of Poland and Japan's Ayaka Taguchi, to underline her potential. After recovering from wrist surgery, the brave Arundhati got the better of World Boxing Cup medallist German Leonie Muller and World Championships medallist



**All 20 Indian boxers competing at the five-day season-ender at the Shaheed Vijay Singh Pathik Sports Complex finished on the podium, with 15 reaching the finals of their respective categories.**